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LOCKDOWN

24 MARCH 2020

INDIA | 485 ACTIVE CASES | 11 DEATHS

WORLD | 3,90,352 ACTIVE CASES | 19,584 DEATHS

The prime minister was scheduled to deliver yet another difficult address to the nation. However, the overwhelming response to his call to stay home for a day-long junta curfew bolstered his spirit—especially the *bhagidari* from the Northeast. So positively overpowering was the response, that *The Telegraph*, which most often takes an anti-establishment stand, published a piece titled, 'Junta Curfew unites Northeast' with heartening quotes that reporters on ground had collected from people. One individual who was playing a guitar outside his home had said to the reporters, 'Thanking people who are working tirelessly for [the] welfare of humanity is a good gesture. Now we cannot thank them in person by shaking hands, but I am sure this resounding thanksgiving will do wonders for them.' Another woman seen beating a steel plate had said, 'This is a unique call by the PM. I am happy to be a part of it. We should not forget the sacrifice of the emergency workers and all those who are working tirelessly to prevent the spread of the disease and also for those who have lost their battle while fighting.'[1] The prime minister now had the confidence that although the stringent restrictions he was about to announce may come across as draconian to a few, his mantra would be '*jaan hai toh jahaan hai* (if you are alive, you can have the world)'. With a resolve to save as many Indian lives as possible, he was going to ask 1.3 billion people to stay put for the next 21 days, at the very least.

Strategically, he scheduled his address to the nation for 8.00 p.m., when shops and activity for the day would have died down. Had it been earlier in